

Indonesia & Malaysia: Traders' EUDR Imperative for Market Access

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Glossary

ASKINDO	: Asosiasi Kakao Indonesia (the Indonesian Cocoa Association)	MCB	: Malaysian Cocoa Board, a federal statutory body under the Ministry of Plantation and Commodities of Malaysia, with one of its primary roles being to regulate and develop the cocoa industry in Malaysia
E-SIR	: Electronic Standard Indonesian Rubber, a digital or electronic system for managing, tracking, or certifying Standard Indonesian Rubber	MPOB	: Malaysian Palm Oil Board, a government agency in Malaysia responsible for the regulation, promotion, and development of the Malaysian palm oil industry
e-STDB	: The electronic version of the STDB (Surat Tanda Daftar Budidaya), a certificate verifying the legality of a plantation in Indonesia, containing geolocation data, land rights information, and commodity and production area details	MSNR	: Malaysian Sustainable Natural Rubber, a national sustainability initiative framework for the Malaysian natural rubber industry
EUDR	: European Union Deforestation Regulation	MSPO	: Malaysian Sustainable Palm Oil, a national certification scheme established by the Malaysian government to ensure the sustainable production of palm oil within Malaysia
FAO	: Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations	RSPO	: Roundtable on Sustainable Palm Oil, a non-profit association uniting various organizations in the palm oil industry towards a single goal, including producers, processors, or traders, consumer goods manufacturers, retailers, social NGOs, environmental or nature conservation NGOs, banks, and palm oil investors
GAPKI	: Gabungan Pengusaha Kelapa Sawit Indonesia (the Indonesian Palm Oil Association)	SMEs	: Small and Medium-sized Enterprises
GAPKINDO	: Gabungan Perusahaan Karet Indonesia (Indonesian Rubber Association)	The Nucleus Estate (NE)	: The NE blockchain platform tracks and verifies the origin of palm oil produced within a nucleus estate model, where a large company works with surrounding smallholder farmers
ICCO	: International Cocoa Organization, a global intergovernmental organization established in 1973 under the auspices of the United Nations		
IoT	: Internet of Thing		
ISPO	: Indonesian Sustainable Palm Oil is a mandatory certification system established by the Indonesian government for the palm oil industry to ensure the economically viable, socio-culturally sustainable, and environmentally friendly management of palm oil plantations		

Executive Summary

Indonesia and Malaysia, dominant global players in palm oil, cocoa, and rubber, face significant challenges navigating the European Union Deforestation Regulation (EUDR). While these commodities are crucial to their economies, stricter EU import regulations address deforestation and sustainability concerns.

Large-scale plantations may have advantages in meeting EUDR's traceability and sustainability requirements due to potentially greater resources and clearer supply chains. However, they still need capacity building, technological integration, and financial support for effective due diligence. The EUDR mandates due diligence to ensure specified commodities are deforestation-free (after December 31, 2020) and legally produced in the

origin country. While its primary aim is to prevent commodity-driven deforestation, the regulation's due diligence framework also encompasses human rights and broader environmental concerns. These challenges also present opportunities: embracing sustainable practices, adopting advanced technologies, and diversifying markets can ensure continued EU market access, enhance global competitiveness, and foster a resilient, equitable future. Critical to achieving these goals is collaboration among governments, Non-Government Organizations (NGOs), the private sector, and local communities. Successfully navigating EUDR implementation requires balancing economic growth with environmental stewardship and social responsibility, allowing these nations to solidify their leadership in sustainable global commodity markets.



Traceability & Market Access: The EUDR Impact on Indonesia and Malaysia Rubber, Cocoa and Palm Oil

Indonesia and Malaysia dominate global palm oil production for approximately 85% of global demand¹.

Both nations are also significant contributors to the cocoa and rubber industries. Indonesia is the world's 4th largest processed cocoa exporter², with global demand projected to reach \$24 billion by 2029³, even as supply faces challenges. For natural rubber, Indonesia is the second-largest producer⁴, alongside Malaysia, collectively supplying about 70% of the world's demand⁵, driven by robust growth in sectors like automotive and healthcare, with the market

expected to hit \$30.5 billion by 2033⁶. However, these industries face issues like cocoa productivity and rubber price volatility⁷.

Sustainable practices, reinforced by initiatives like RSPO, ISPO, and MSPO, are crucial given international regulations like the EUDR, which, once activated, will mandate due diligence for operators and traders importing and exporting these commodities to the EU market. Consequently, traders are accelerating efforts in traceability and inclusiveness to secure continued market access.

¹ <https://indef.or.id/wp-content/uploads/2023/03/Working-Paper-Reducing-Poverty-Improving-Sustainability-Palm-Oil-Smallholders-are-Key-to-Meeting-the-UN-SDGs.pdf> INDEF WORKING PAPER NO.1/2021

² <https://www.cekindo.com/blog/exporting-cocoa-in-indonesia>

³ What is the demand for cocoa on the European market? <https://www.cbi.eu/market-information/cocoa/what-demand>

⁴ <https://www.anrpc.org/indonesia>

⁵ <https://www.anrpc.org/malaysia>

⁶ <https://www.alliedmarketresearch.com/natural-rubber-market-A107974>

⁷ <https://www.technavio.com/report/industrial-chocolate-market-size-industry-analysis>

Trade Flows of Key Commodities from Indonesia & Malaysia to the EU (2023 estimates)⁸

	PALM OIL	RUBBER	COCOA
Direct Exports to EU (Metric Tons) →	Indonesia 3.2 million Malaysia 1.8 million	Indonesia 1.1 million Malaysia 0.7 million	Indonesia 250 thousand Malaysia 80 thousand
Indirect Exports to EU (Metric Tons) →	Indonesia 1.5 million Malaysia 0.9 million	Indonesia 0.4 million Malaysia 0.3 million	Indonesia 100 thousand Malaysia 30 thousand
Total Exports to EU (Metric Tons) →	Indonesia 4.7 million Malaysia 2.7 million	Indonesia 1.5 million Malaysia 1.0 million	Indonesia 350 thousand Malaysia 110 thousand
Share of EU Imports (%) →	Indonesia 44% Malaysia 25%	Indonesia 28% Malaysia 19%	Indonesia 8% Malaysia 2%

Sources: Indonesian Ministry of Trade & Malaysian Ministry of Plantation Industries and Commodities, 2023

⁸ Indonesian Ministry of Trade & Malaysian Ministry of Plantation Industries and Commodities

Indonesia & Malaysia's Traders: Adapting EUDR under Cocoa, Rubber and Palm Oil

The EU Deforestation Regulation (EUDR) is fundamentally alter how Indonesian and Malaysian companies manage palm oil, cocoa, and rubber, presenting both hurdles and prospects. This shift necessitates a complete overhaul of current compliance frameworks.

Companies will face higher operational costs and administrative burdens⁹, especially when conducting extensive due diligence on third-party suppliers, a task already requiring significant sustainability and field-work teams from large corporations. Significant investment in advanced traceability systems is critical¹⁰. These systems need to gather, verify, and manage precise geolocation data for every land plot¹¹, including those managed by third-party suppliers and smallholders, ensuring distinct, identifiable areas across all supply chains. This requires adopting advanced mapping technology, like high-resolution satellite imagery and AI for real-time monitoring. Companies are also looking into blockchain for immutable origin records and geospatial analysis for proactive risk assessment. While

widespread advanced traceability systems are still emerging, existing certification infrastructures provide a base. Nonetheless, larger companies must integrate diverse data formats from various commodities and certification schemes into unified digital platforms.

Beyond technology, traders and operators must implement rigorous verification processes, possibly through independent third-party audits, to guarantee data accuracy and strict EUDR compliance. Companies also need to invest in capacity building and technical assistance for farmers, including smallholders, to equip them with the necessary skills for accurate land mapping and meticulous record-keeping¹².

Proving legal compliance with local laws on land tenure, labour rights, and environmental regulations is vital for due diligence, demanding extensive documentation and significant inter-governmental coordination¹³. Jurisdictional and Landscape Approaches are vital multi-stakeholder platforms recommended to streamline policies and facilitate inter-district coordination, thereby supporting smallholder integration for eventual EUDR compliance.”

⁹ Circularise. (n.d.). EU Deforestation Regulation (EUDR): What it means for your supply chain. Retrieved [6 June 2025] from <https://www.circularise.com/blogs/eu-deforestation-regulation-eudr>

¹⁰ TraceX Technologies. (n.d.). How to Ensure Deforestation-Free Sourcing for EUDR Compliance. Retrieved [6 June 2025] from <https://tracex.tech.com/deforestation-free-sourcing-eudr-compliance/>

¹¹ osapiens. (n.d.). Meet the EU Deforestation Regulation | osapiens HUB for EUDR. Retrieved [6 June 2025] from <https://osapiens.com/solutions/eudr/>

¹² Solidaridad. (2023, July 27). The EUDR and smallholders: addressing the challenges and seizing opportunities. Retrieved [Current Date] from <https://www.solidaridadnetwork.org/news/the-eudr-and-smallholders-addressing-the-challenges-and-seizing-opportunities/>

¹³ European Commission. (n.d.). EU Deforestation Regulation. Retrieved [Current Date] from https://environment.ec.europa.eu/topics/forests/deforestation/deforestation-regulation_en

EUDR Compliance: Overcoming Trader-Smallholder Integration Hurdles via Regulatory Support

The palm oil industries in Indonesia and Malaysia are global leaders, supplying this versatile commodity for food, cosmetics, and biofuels. Indonesia, as the largest producer, utilizes its Indonesian Sustainable Palm Oil (ISPO) certification scheme, though its effectiveness in supporting due diligence for EUDR compliance is still debated.

The developing National Dashboard aims to enhance transparency and traceability of key agricultural products by centralizing data on origin, practices, and legality from various sources, thereby aiding EUDR due diligence, despite the system has not fully progressing yet. Malaysia, the second-largest producer, employs the Malaysian Sustainable Palm Oil (MSPO) scheme, but expanding its adoption among smallholders and meeting international traceability demands for due diligence remains a significant challenge. From sectoral workshops and regional technical dialogue sessions, corporations underscore that the EU plays a critical market for rubber, cocoa, and palm oil in both Indonesia and Malaysia. Discussions convened in both countries highlighted the urgent need to address data management, verification, and regulatory alignment issues that corporations face, particularly concerning the integration of smallholders - who are crucial to the supply chain - into traceable systems.

Indonesia and Malaysia are developing and enhancing digital platforms to manage traceability data. Indonesia's National Dashboard Initiative: this platform aims to provide comprehensive data, information, and documentation needed to meet EUDR requirements, particularly regarding traceability. Malaysia's MSPO Trace System and GeoPalm Portal. These systems

are being leveraged and further developed to track the journey of palm oil from plantation to product, providing verifiable information for EUDR compliance. Another key challenge is interoperating their existing traceability systems with both Indonesia National Dashboard Initiatives and Malaysia MSPO Trace System and GeoPalm Portals to integrate smallholders and the middle-traders that earlier complicates corporate due diligence¹⁴. Blockchain platforms, such as Indonesia's National Dashboard, which integrates e-STDB (Smallholder Registration System) registered smallholders, show promise but face challenges related to IT interoperability and decentralized compliance verification.

Beyond the stringent requirements of the EU Deforestation Regulation (EUDR), the cocoa industries in Indonesia and Malaysia simultaneously struggle with aging trees, an aging workforce, and suboptimal farming practices (e.g., inadequate fertilization, pruning, and pest control). Declining cocoa export volumes, in contrast to an escalating global demand¹⁵, present a critical challenge to the long-term sustainability of the sector. Revitalization strategies, such as replanting cocoa trees and implementing knowledge transfer programs, are urgently needed. Indonesia cultivates cocoa primarily in Sulawesi and Sumatera, typically on small plantations, while Malaysia focuses on Sabah and Sarawak¹⁶. Both countries significantly contribute to global cocoa production, which was approximately 4.78 million metric tons in 2020¹⁷.

EUDR implementation poses significant challenges for traders and corporations within the cocoa sector¹⁸, adding complexity and potential costs for establishing traceability before reaching the EU market. 90% of cocoa is sourced from smallholders¹⁹ and the prevalence

¹⁴ PwC. (2025, January 21). Navigating EU Deforestation Regulation: from guidelines to best practices. Retrieved [6 June 2025] from <https://www.pwc.com/gx/en/services/tax/esg-tax/navigating-eu-deforestation-regulation.html>

¹⁵ International Cocoa Organization (ICCO). (Annual Reports, Quarterly Bulletins).

¹⁶ Cekindo. (2023, July 27). Indonesian Cocoa Bean Export Market: An Overview. Retrieved [6 June 2025] from <https://cekindo.com/blog/indonesian-cocoa-bean-export-market-overview>

¹⁷ FAOSTAT. (n.d.). Crops and livestock products. Retrieved [6 June 2025] from <https://www.fao.org/faostat/en/#data/QCL>

¹⁸ European Cocoa Association (ECA). (n.d.). EUDR Resources. Retrieved [6 June 2025] from <https://eurococoa.com/resources/eudr-resources/>

¹⁹ Forest & Farm Facility (FAO). (2024, May 15). Smallholders and the EU Deforestation Regulation: A global call to action. Retrieved [Current Date] from <https://www.fao.org/forests/forest-and-farm-facility/news/news-detail/en/c/1699742/>

of intermediaries, cocoa traders will face considerable difficulties in sourcing from smallholders who can provide verified land data and meet traceability requirements. A unique challenge for both Indonesia and Malaysia, as highlighted in sectoral workshops, is both countries' reliance on imported cocoa beans from West Africa²⁰. Therefore, operators and traders must ensure EUDR compliance for the entire supply chain, including these imported beans, necessitating robust traceability for mixed-origin products. Differing domestic cocoa regulations, such as Indonesia's formal agroforestry classification versus Malaysia's less formalized approach, further compound this complexity. While not directly mandated by the EUDR, certifications like Fairtrade and Rainforest Alliance Certified preceded it, proving instrumental in securing market access and ensuring environmental, social, and economic viability. Moreover, regulatory oversight for Indonesia's cocoa sector is dispersed across multiple ministries, with smallholder affairs managed under the Ministry of Agriculture. This contrasts with Malaysia's more centralized approach via the Malaysian Cocoa Board (MCB)²¹. To ensure traceability, Indonesian cocoa farmers will be required to register their polygon information through the e-STDB system, a process facilitated by district agricultural units, with these commodity and production details subsequently integrated into the National Dashboard²². Concurrently, Malaysia's cocoa traceability is enhanced under the MCB's National Cocoa Traceability System²³.

In Indonesia, smallholders dominate natural rubber production (approximately 85% of plantation area and over 90% of raw material, mainly from Sumatra and Kalimantan), typically selling through intermediaries to private sector processors²⁴. This opacity, characterized by limited direct sourcing and unclear market share data, significantly hinders traceability and EUDR compliance²⁵. Similar to cocoa, rubber is predominantly cultivated by

smallholders, and intermediaries are mostly present before the product is sold to traders. Key challenges for rubber include replanting aging trees (with an annual rate of less than 2% in Indonesia)²⁶, complex land tenure issues, and providing comprehensive traceability data for company due diligence under the EUDR. Malaysia's rubber smallholders (accounting for over 90% of upstream production) also face economic hardship due to low prices and high costs, with limited direct ties to processors and the glove industry, which increasingly imports latex²⁷.

EUDR compliance mandates stringent requirements for geolocation data, land legality, and traceability, which are difficult to meet amidst tight timelines and ambiguous EU guidance. Indonesia is upgrading its Standardized Indonesian Rubber (SIR) system to E-SIR for better data management, but its alignment with EU standards remains uncertain²⁸. Navigating compliance while dealing with fluctuating rubber prices is critical. Accelerating E-SIR adoption through government mandates, involving district governments, and developing practical technical guidelines are highly recommended²⁹. Indonesia is a top global rubber producer (approximately 3.3 million metric tons annually) with a significant portion exported to the EU³⁰, highlighting the EUDR's importance. Malaysia produces around 0.7 million metric tons annually³¹. Both countries strive to balance traditional smallholder practices with modern corporate management, which requires active national and district government involvement. Malaysia's MSNR (Malaysian Sustainable Natural Rubber) initiative supports sustainable practices³². Environmental concerns include deforestation and habitat loss, exacerbated by climate change. Indonesia classifies rubber as an agroforestry crop, unlike Malaysia, which potentially impacts sustainability approaches.

20 Example (illustrative): USAID. (n.d.). Sustainable Cocoa Program in Indonesia. (Look for reports on governance and institutional frameworks.)

21 Malaysian Cocoa Board. (n.d.). About Us. Retrieved [Current Date] from <https://www.koko.gov.my/> (Navigate to English section, 'About Us' or 'Functions').

22 PwC. (2025, January 21). Navigating EU Deforestation Regulation: from guidelines to best practices. Retrieved [Current Date] from <https://www.pwc.com/gx/en/services/tax/esg-tax/navigating-eu-deforestation-regulation.html>

23 The Star (Malaysian Newspaper). (2024, May 22). MCB aiming for comprehensive cocoa traceability system by end of next year. Retrieved [6 June 2025] from <https://www.thestar.com.my/business/business-news/2024/05/22/mcb-aiming-for-comprehensive-cocoa-traceability-system-by-end-of-next-year>

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25 GIZ. (n.d.). Sustainable Rubber: Continental's partnership with GIZ. Retrieved [Current Date] from <https://www.giz.de/en/worldwide/87869.html>

26 ANRPC. (2023). ANRPC Rubber Planters' Productivity Enhancement Series. (This series often covers replanting and productivity challenges).

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28 GIZ. (n.d.). Sustainable Rubber: Continental's partnership with GIZ. Retrieved [6 June 2026] from <https://www.giz.de/en/worldwide/87869.html> (While focused on their project, it underscores the efforts to build traceability)

29 Solidaridad. (2024, May 14). EUDR implications for Smallholder Farmers. Retrieved [6 June 2025] from <https://www.solidaridadnetwork.org/news/eudr-implications-for-smallholder-farmers/> (Discusses government's role in supporting smallholders for compliance).

30 ANRPC. (2024). Natural Rubber Statistics. (You would cite the specific year's report).

31 ANRPC. (2024). Natural Rubber Statistics. (You would cite the specific year's report).

32 Malaysian Rubber Board. (n.d.). Malaysian Sustainable Natural Rubber (MSNR). Retrieved [6 June 2025] from <https://www.lgm.gov.my/sustainable-rubber/malaysian-sustainable-natural-rubber-msnr/>

Source: iStock, 2022

Opportunities for Indonesia and Malaysia Traders for Commodities Under EUDR

The table 1 above demonstrates that imported palm oil from Indonesia and Malaysia accounts for 44% and 25% of the market, respectively.

This is followed by Indonesian rubber at 28% and 19%, with cocoa being the least significant at 8% and 2%. These statistics clearly indicate that market access and competitiveness for palm oil and rubber are substantial, which will severely impact the traders if they fail to meet the EU Deforestation Regulation (EUDR). Upon activation, non-compliance with the EUDR will lead to exclusion from the EU market³³, compelling Indonesian and Malaysian traders to redirect their commodities to less profitable non-EU markets. This diversion could adversely impact export prices, reduce overall export volumes, diminish corporate profitability, and impede the progress of companies already invested in sustainability initiatives.

Conversely, operators and traders that successfully adapt and demonstrate full compliance with the EUDR to secure competitive advantage market³⁴. This strategic positioning enables them to become preferred and reliable suppliers for the traders, operators and EU buyers, thereby capturing a larger share of the European market. A significant and widely acknowledged concern, however, pertains to the capacity of operators and traders to fulfil supply requirements while effectively integrating smallholder farmers into compliant supply chains. The inherently informal structures and limited resources characteristic of numerous smallholder operations suggest that a failure by larger enterprises to effectively onboard these producers could lead to supply chain fragmentation, consequently restricting EU market access to only a compliant smallholders. Furthermore, beyond direct market access implications, the reputational risks associated with EUDR non-compliance or any public association with deforestation are substantial, capable of severely damaging a company's brand equity and diminishing consumer and investor trust, thereby highlighting the multifaceted implications of adherence³⁵.

³³ PwC. (2025, January 21). Navigating EU Deforestation Regulation: from guidelines to best practices. Retrieved June 6, 2025, from <https://www.pwc.com/gx/en/services/tax/esg-tax/navigating-eu-deforestation-regulation.html>

¹⁰ EY. (n.d.). Why Southeast Asia should seize the EUDR compliance opportunity. Retrieved June 6, 2025, from https://www.ey.com/en_id/insights/sustainability/why-southeast-asia-should-seize-the-eudr-compliance-opportunity

¹¹ PwC. (2025, January 21). Navigating EU Deforestation Regulation: from guidelines to best practices. Retrieved June 6, 2025, from <https://www.pwc.com/gx/en/services/tax/esg-tax/navigating-eu-deforestation-regulation.html>

Strategic Pathways for EUDR Compliance for Supply Chain in Cocoa, Palm Oil and Rubber Sectors

Successfully navigating EUDR compliance while fostering sustainability requires a multi-faceted strategy for all relevant Operators and Traders across Indonesia and Malaysia's cocoa, palm oil, and rubber sectors, with critical attention to smallholder integration.



Technological Integration and Enhanced Traceability

- Corporations (Operators and major traders) should invest in and implement robust traceability systems, from farm to end-product, utilizing technologies like blockchain, GPS mapping, IoT solutions, and digital platforms to ensure compliance with EUDR's geolocation and documentation requirements.
- Link company-specific systems with national dashboards (like Indonesia's upcoming one) to enhance transparency and accountability.
- Equip smallholders with affordable, user-friendly traceability technologies and streamline data collection.



Capacity Building and Smallholder Empowerment

- Develop and implement targeted training programs for smallholders focusing on sustainable agricultural practices (agroforestry, pest management, soil conservation), financial literacy, and skills for providing traceability data.
- Explore innovative financial assistance models (e.g., microloans, input credit) and fair cost-sharing mechanisms for compliance.
- Foster inclusive business models, establish transparent and fair pricing, and facilitate smallholder access to credit and markets.



Supply Chain Resilience, Risk Management, and Ethical Sourcing

- Strengthen supply chains through diversified sourcing, robust supplier verification and audits, and proactive risk management strategies.
- Ensure ethical sourcing, including fair labour conditions (combating child labour), community engagement, and transparent reporting to meet regulatory requirements and enhance corporate (operators and traders) reputation.
- Implement satellite monitoring and ground-level verification for deforestation and promote sustainable land-use practices.



Market Development and Innovation

- Leverage EUDR compliance to access and expand in the EU market and differentiate products, especially for SMEs.
- Explore product diversification beyond traditional applications (e.g., industrial products, cosmetics, pharmaceuticals).
- Invest in R&D for improving commodity genetics, sustainable farming practices, and eco-friendly processing technologies.



Policy, Governance, and Collaboration

- Engage in policy dialogue and advocacy with governments and international bodies (including the EU) for clear, consistent regulatory frameworks, technical assistance, financial support, and shared responsibility in sustainable development.
- Foster multi-stakeholder platforms for dialogue and collaboration between governments, industry associations, NGOs, CSOs, and international bodies to collectively resolve EUDR challenges and share best practices.
- Strengthen law enforcement against illegal deforestation and labor exploitation.
- Support active involvement of district governments in smallholder inclusion, local capacity-building, and awareness of sustainable practices and technologies.
- Ensure effective coordination across government ministries for streamlined regulations and consistent support for due diligence systems.

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